



## VASCULAR PLANTS

The majority of plants are vascular and include ferns, conifers, and flowering plants. Most reproduce using seeds, which grow inside a flower, fruit, or cone (see pp.80–81). Vascular plants can grow tall because their cell walls contain a stiffening compound called lignin.

### Flowering plants

are the most diverse group with 268,000 known species. A quarter of these belong to just three families—the orchids, the peas, and the sunflowers.



### Conifers

are woody plants with long, narrow, or scale-like leaves. Their seeds grow inside a protective cone before being dropped to the ground. Conifers include pines, cedars, firs, and redwoods.



### Ferns

are leafy plants with stems, leaves, and roots, but which reproduce using spores. There are around 12,000 species of fern, including horsetails, snake-tongued ferns, and whisk ferns.



# Growing up

There are more than 300,000 species of plants on Earth. Without them, there would never have been enough OXYGEN in the atmosphere or the seas to *support animal life*. Plants thrive everywhere except for the icy poles, the dry deserts, and the deep oceans.



Every part of a flowering plant, like this hibiscus, has a special function to help it grow: the leaves produce food, the roots suck up water, and the flowers hold the seeds for reproduction.